

Trainer Guide

Communicating Up: Building Confidence Across Generations

Project	New Intern Onboarding Communication Training
Audience	New graduate interns
Duration	90 minutes
Format	Interactive instructor-led workshop
Experience theme	Communication Challenge Lab
Version	v1.0

1. Facilitator Overview

This trainer guide supports a 90-minute interactive onboarding workshop for new graduate interns at NorthStar Rail. The session helps interns communicate clearly, professionally, and confidently with managers, senior leaders, and experienced employees.

Item	Guidance
Course goal	By the end of the training, interns will be able to adapt their communication style when interacting with senior managers and leaders by using clear structure, professional tone, active listening, and feedback-response strategies.
Design approach	Scenario-based, challenge-driven, low-lecture, high-participation.
Facilitator tone	Supportive, practical, energetic, inclusive, and professional.
Participation rule	Learners should do something every 7-10 minutes: vote, write, discuss, rewrite, practice, or reflect.

2. Learning Objectives

#	By the end of the session, learners will be able to...
1	Identify common communication expectations between interns and senior leaders.
2	Differentiate casual, professional, and leadership-facing communication styles.
3	Apply the CLEAR framework to emails, chats, and verbal updates.
4	Demonstrate how to ask specific questions and clarify expectations.
5	Respond to feedback using a professional and growth-oriented approach.
6	Create a personal 30-day communication action plan.

3. Materials and Setup

Material	Purpose	Facilitator Notes
Slide deck	Visual support and activity prompts	Open before learners arrive.
Participant worksheet	Learner reflection and practice	Print one per learner or share digitally.
CLEAR checklist	Job aid for workplace transfer	Distribute during Module 2.
Scenario cards	Group and pair activities	Print/cut for in-person, or paste into chat for virtual.
Polling tool or sticky notes	Opening participation	Use Teams/Zoom poll, Mentimeter, or sticky notes.
Timer	Activity pacing	Keep practice activities short and energetic.
Post-session survey	Evaluation	Send immediately after the workshop.

4. Session Flow

Section	Time	Focus	Primary Activity
Opening: Communication Reality Check	10 min	Relevance and psychological safety	Poll + discussion
Module 1: Manager Lens	15 min	Senior manager expectations	Scenario analysis
Module 2: CLEAR Framework	20 min	Structured communication	Message-building practice
Module 3: Message Makeover Challenge	20 min	Professional tone in email/chat	Team rewrite challenge
Module 4: Ask Better Questions	15 min	Speaking up and clarifying expectations	Pair role-play
Module 5: Feedback and Follow-Up	5 min	Responding to feedback	Best-response activity
Closing: 30-Day Commitment	5 min	Transfer to workplace	Individual action plan

5. Detailed Facilitation Plan

Opening: Communication Reality Check

Time	Purpose
10 minutes	Create relevance, normalize communication anxiety, and invite participation early.

Facilitator Actions

- Welcome learners and introduce the session as a Communication Challenge Lab, not a lecture.
- Explain that the goal is to practice realistic communication choices in a safe environment.
- Launch the opening poll: What feels hardest when communicating with senior managers or leaders?

- Debrief the poll and connect results to the session purpose.

Learner Actions

- Vote individually.
- Briefly discuss the poll results.
- Write one personal communication concern in the worksheet.

Key Message

These challenges are normal for new professionals. The goal is not to become someone else. The goal is to communicate with more clarity, confidence, and awareness of what managers need.

Assessment Check

Learners can name at least one communication challenge relevant to their internship.

Module 1: Manager Lens

Time	Purpose
15 minutes	Help interns understand what senior managers need from communication.

Facilitator Actions

- Present the Manager Lens expectations: clear, concise, timely, action-oriented, professional, and ownership-based.
- Show the weak message scenario: “Hi, I’m confused about the data. Can you help?”
- Ask groups to identify what is missing and what the manager still needs.
- Invite two or three groups to share, then summarize key gaps.

Learner Actions

- Analyze the scenario in small groups.
- Identify missing context, unclear ask, urgency, and next step.
- Record the improved communication needs in the worksheet.

Key Message

Managers are not looking for perfect wording. They need enough context to understand the issue and take action quickly.

Assessment Check

Learners can explain why a manager needs context, specificity, and a next step.

Module 2: The CLEAR Framework

Time	Purpose
20 minutes	Give learners a repeatable structure for manager-ready communication.

Facilitator Actions

- Introduce CLEAR: Context, Lead with the point, Explain briefly, Ask or action, Recap next step.
- Model how the weak message becomes a CLEAR message.
- Assign the vendor proposal practice scenario.
- Ask learners to draft individually, compare in pairs, and improve their message.
- Invite one or two examples and provide supportive feedback.

Learner Actions

- Complete the CLEAR template individually.
- Compare with a partner.
- Revise the message and identify which CLEAR element improved the most.

Key Message

A clear structure helps managers respond faster and helps interns sound prepared, confident, and respectful.

Assessment Check

Learners produce a message containing all five CLEAR elements.

Module 3: Message Makeover Challenge

Time	Purpose
20 minutes	Help interns adjust tone and clarity for email and chat.

Facilitator Actions

- Explain that professional communication is respectful, clear, useful, concise, and confident.
- Divide learners into small teams and assign each team a weak message.
- Ask teams to rewrite the message for a senior manager or project lead.
- Use the scorecard to evaluate clarity, tone, request, conciseness, and next step.
- Have teams share original and improved versions. Optionally let the room vote on the strongest improvement.

Learner Actions

- Rewrite a weak message in teams.
- Use the scorecard to self-check.
- Share the improved version and explain the changes.

Key Message

Professional does not mean cold or robotic. It means the message is easy to understand and easy to act on.

Assessment Check

Learners revise a message to improve tone, clarity, and actionability.

Module 4: Ask Better Questions

Time	Purpose
15 minutes	Build confidence in speaking up and clarifying expectations.

Facilitator Actions

- Explain the structure of a strong question: what I did, what I am unsure about, what I need, and what happens next.
- Present the project update role-play scenario.
- Ask learners to practice in pairs: one intern, one manager.
- Invite volunteers to share one strong clarifying question.
- Debrief that asking specific questions shows preparation.

Learner Actions

- Practice asking clarifying questions in pairs.
- Switch roles if time allows.
- Write one question starter they will use at work.

Key Message

Asking questions does not make you look unprepared. A clear, specific question shows that you are thinking ahead and trying to deliver the right result.

Assessment Check

Learners ask a specific question that includes context, clarification, and next step.

Module 5: Feedback and Follow-Up

Time	Purpose
5 minutes	Help interns respond calmly and constructively to feedback.

Facilitator Actions

- Show the feedback scenario and four possible responses.

- Ask learners to choose the strongest response.
- Confirm that response C is strongest because it acknowledges, clarifies, and acts.
- Share the feedback response structure: Acknowledge, Clarify, Act, Learn.

Learner Actions

- Choose the best response.
- Explain why it is stronger.
- Write one feedback sentence starter.

Key Message

Feedback is not a personal failure. It is part of workplace learning and improvement.

Assessment Check

Learners can identify a professional response to feedback.

Closing: 30-Day Communication Commitment

Time	Purpose
5 minutes	Support transfer from training to workplace.

Facilitator Actions

- Ask learners to complete the 30-day action plan.
- Invite optional sharing with a partner.
- Remind learners to use the CLEAR checklist for one manager update in the next two weeks.
- Close with a confidence-building message.

Learner Actions

- Complete the action plan.
- Choose one workplace situation where they will apply CLEAR.
- Submit or keep the plan based on program preference.

Key Message

Communication is a workplace skill that improves with practice. You do not need perfect wording every time. What matters is clarity, respect, and ownership.

Assessment Check

Learners leave with one specific communication behavior to apply during the internship.

6. Activity Appendix

Opening Poll

What feels hardest when communicating with senior managers or leaders?

- A. I do not know how formal I should be.
- B. I worry my question sounds obvious.
- C. I do not know how much detail to include.
- D. I feel nervous speaking in meetings.
- E. I am not sure how to respond to feedback.

Message Makeover Prompts

Prompt	Weak Message
Too casual	Hey, just wondering if you saw my thing from yesterday lol. Need your thoughts when you can.
Too vague	Hi, I have a question about the project. Can we talk?
Too long	Hi Maria, I was looking at the report and then I checked the file that Sam sent, but I also saw another version in the

	folder, and I am not totally sure which one is right because they look kind of similar but also different, so I was wondering if maybe you could let me know what you think when you have time.
Too passive	Sorry to bother you, but I do not really know if this is right. Maybe I can change it if you want.

Facilitator Debrief Questions

- What made the improved message easier to act on?
- What details were helpful, and what details were unnecessary?
- How did the tone change without becoming too formal?
- Where could you use this structure during your internship?

7. Virtual Delivery Adaptations

In-Person Activity	Virtual Adaptation
Sticky-note poll	Use Teams/Zoom poll or chat reactions.
Small-group table discussion	Use breakout rooms with a time limit and clear task.
Scenario cards	Paste one scenario into each breakout room chat or shared document.
Pair role-play	Use breakout rooms of two or three learners.
Group share-out	Ask each room to post one improved message in chat.

8. Post-Session Reinforcement

Timing	Reinforcement Action
Immediately after training	Send the CLEAR checklist and completed worksheet.
Within 2 weeks	Ask interns to apply CLEAR to one manager update.
After 30 days	Manager asks: What communication habit have you been practicing, and where would you like more feedback?
End of internship	Add a reflection question to the intern program evaluation.

9. Evaluation Questions

- The session felt relevant to my internship role.
- The activities kept me engaged and participating.
- I can use the CLEAR framework to communicate with my manager.
- I feel more confident asking questions or clarifying expectations.
- I know how to respond professionally to feedback.
- One thing I will apply in the next 30 days is: _____